

GRI | UBER RESEARCH PROJECT

ALGORITHMIC MANAGEMENT AND THE \$20 GROSS EARNINGS BAND

Consolidated research dossier and primary offer evidence

South Florida | Uber and Lyft comparative field research | October 7, 2026

Research status: Exploratory working paper. The evidence comprises three documented Lyft fare offers and two earlier GRI research publications. It does not establish algorithmic intent, realized hourly wages, or platform wide compensation policy.

Archive structure: Section A: new primary offer evidence and methods update; Section B: The Uber Research Platform (original October 7 paper); Section C: Algorithmic Management and the Approximately \$20 Gross Earnings Band (original October 5 brief).

PRINCIPAL FINDING

Across three displayed trip offers totaling 88 minutes, the combined advertised compensation equals \$20.54 per displayed trip hour, or \$19.79 after excluding the single identifiable \$1.10 bonus.

The denominator is displayed trip duration, not online time or total driver labor time. All results are gross, before operating expenses.

Custody and privacy: Screenshots contain passenger first names and approximate route endpoints. Treat the full dossier as an internal evidentiary record; redact identifying information before public distribution.

A1. Evidence register and calculation protocol

The three screenshots were supplied October 7, 2026. All list scheduled pickups for the next day. This register records what is visible on the offer screen without assuming acceptance or ride completion. An unrelated phone notification in Observation 003 does not identify the fare platform; the ride offer user interface matches the Lyft series, but the original account record should be used for definitive platform attribution.

ID	Displayed fare	Minutes	Miles	Displayed \$/hr	Displayed \$/mile
L 001	\$10.11	29	21.1	\$20.92	\$0.48
L 002	\$5.01 incl. \$1.10 bonus	12	4.5	\$25.05	\$1.11
L 003	\$15.00	47	25.2	\$19.15	\$0.60

Method: Offer hourly equivalent = (offered compensation / displayed minutes) x 60. Revenue per displayed mile = offer / displayed miles. Bonus adjusted Observation 002 = (\$5.01 - \$1.10) / 12 x 60 = \$19.55/hour. All amounts rounded to two decimals.

Aggregate, weighted by trip time

Numerator	Total minutes	Gross equivalent
\$30.12 total offered across three observations	88	\$20.54/hour
\$29.02 excluding known \$1.10 bonus	88	\$19.79/hour

Correction to earlier conversation calculation: The arithmetic aggregate is **\$20.54/hour including bonus** and **\$19.79/hour excluding bonus**, not \$20.73/\$19.98. This dossier uses corrected results. The individual observation equivalents remain \$20.92, \$25.05 and \$19.15.

Known exclusions

Offer screenshots do not establish platform payment actually received, pickup distance, pickup minutes, reservation lead time, early arrival/waiting, repositioning, deadhead return, cancellations, tips, or fuel/depreciation/insurance/maintenance. Also unknown: sampling procedure and how many other offers were displayed or rejected.

A2. Research interpretation and hypotheses

The observed \$19.79 bonus adjusted aggregate hourly equivalent is near the proposed \$20 band, but three observations chosen from a single local market are insufficient to estimate a stable distribution or causal mechanism. All three are scheduled rides, potentially subject to reservation specific pricing and assignment rules.

Competing explanations to test

H1 | Earnings band: The conditional distribution of offered gross dollars per displayed trip hour concentrates near a stable range within particular markets, times and trip types.

H2 | Incentive layer: Explicit bonuses alter displayed hourly equivalents while underlying compensation remains more tightly clustered.

H3 | Market clearing: Demand, supply, traffic, trip mix and acceptance selection produce apparent convergence without a programmed earnings target.

H4 | Denominator sensitivity: Apparent \$20/hour offers result in materially lower online hour and net economic equivalents after pickup, waiting, repositioning and expenses.

H5 | Institutional governance: Algorithmic task allocation and information asymmetry materially shape driver discretion and economic outcomes.

Standardized prospective trial

Capture every eligible offer during predetermined observation windows, whether accepted or declined. Retain exact timestamp, platform, product, reservation flag, offer, bonus, pickup and trip estimates separately, miles, geography, visible surge, acceptance, completion status, realized pay and tips, total online time, total vehicle miles and observed vehicle costs. Calculate two denominators: trip hour and full online labor hour. Track selection and missingness.

Statistical plan

At 30 offers, report descriptive histograms, median, interquartile range, standard deviation and 95% bootstrap intervals with sampling caveats. At larger sample sizes, stratify by platform, reserved versus on demand, time of day, weekday, distance, pickup burden and promotional bonuses; use regression with clustered errors as appropriate. Do not interpret concentration alone as algorithmic intent.

Institutional and academic context

The project frames Uber and Lyft as cases in algorithmic management: software mediated allocation, pricing, incentives, monitoring and feedback. The broader GRI research connects field observations and management theory with information asymmetry, organizational governance and human oversight. Passenger conversations may generate qualitative insight, but should not be treated as a representative survey or formal human subjects study without consent and ethics review.

A3. Sensitivity and cost context

This table shows how assumed non-trip time changes the gross hourly equivalent. It is **not** a measurement of pickup time: the screenshots do not display these values.

Offer	Trip-only	+5 min per offer	+10 min per offer
L 001	\$20.92	\$17.84	\$15.55
L 002	\$25.05	\$17.68	\$13.66
L 003	\$19.15	\$17.31	\$15.79

Context from prior GRI reports: the earlier brief discusses late September 2026 third party Miami tracking approximations of Uber \$18.78/hour and Lyft \$16.73/hour, Florida minimum wage, changes in fuel costs and an IRS mileage benchmark. These are contextual benchmarks, not an independently collected matched sample of the three reservation offers. The IRS optional business mileage rate is a tax method benchmark rather than a direct measurement of each driver's marginal cost.

Management implications

The management question is whether ostensibly flexible contractor work is governed by an opaque decision system that sets key economic parameters while leaving drivers to absorb unremunerated time and vehicle risk. Testing that proposition requires a systematic offer census, platform comparison, and cost accounting.

Fieldwork provenance and next milestones

GRI reports more than a decade of rideshare field exposure, extensive mobility mileage and passenger interactions. Those background claims are practitioner reported and distinct from the three separately recorded October 2026 screenshot observations. Near term: preserve image originals, create cryptographic hashes, register acceptance and completion outcomes, collect 30 consecutive eligible offers, and perform the first preregistered descriptive assessment.

Selected source and framework register

Rosenblat, A. and Stark, L. (2016). Algorithmic Labor and Information Asymmetries: A Case Study of Uber Drivers. *International Journal of Communication* 10.

Hall, J. V. and Krueger, A. B. (2018). An Analysis of the Labor Market for Uber Driver Partners in the United States. *ILR Review* 71(3): 705-732.

GRI (October 7, 2026). The Uber Research Platform. Full source paper reproduced in Section B.

GRI (October 5, 2026). Algorithmic Management and the Approximately \$20 Gross Earnings Band. Full source brief reproduced in Section C.

Anonymized offer record: L 001

Primary observation values preserved

Displayed offer	\$10.11
Displayed trip duration	29 minutes
Displayed trip distance	21.1 miles
Gross trip-hour equivalent	\$20.92
Bonus information	No separately identified bonus

Publication privacy treatment

The source screenshot has been removed from this public edition. Passenger names, precise pickup and destination locations, route maps, times of day and other potentially identifying interface details are omitted. The original source screenshot remains only in the private GRI evidence archive. These observations represent displayed offers, not verified completed rides.

Anonymized offer record: L 002

Primary observation values preserved

Displayed offer	\$5.01
Displayed trip duration	12 minutes
Displayed trip distance	4.5 miles
Gross trip-hour equivalent	\$25.05
Bonus information	\$1.10 known bonus; adjusted equivalent: \$19.55/hour

Publication privacy treatment

The source screenshot has been removed from this public edition. Passenger names, precise pickup and destination locations, route maps, times of day and other potentially identifying interface details are omitted. The original source screenshot remains only in the private GRI evidence archive. These observations represent displayed offers, not verified completed rides.

Anonymized offer record: L 003

Primary observation values preserved

Displayed offer	\$15.00
Displayed trip duration	47 minutes
Displayed trip distance	25.2 miles
Gross trip-hour equivalent	\$19.15
Bonus information	No separately identified bonus

Publication privacy treatment

The source screenshot has been removed from this public edition. Passenger names, precise pickup and destination locations, route maps, times of day and other potentially identifying interface details are omitted. The original source screenshot remains only in the private GRI evidence archive. These observations represent displayed offers, not verified completed rides.

THE UBER RESEARCH PLATFORM

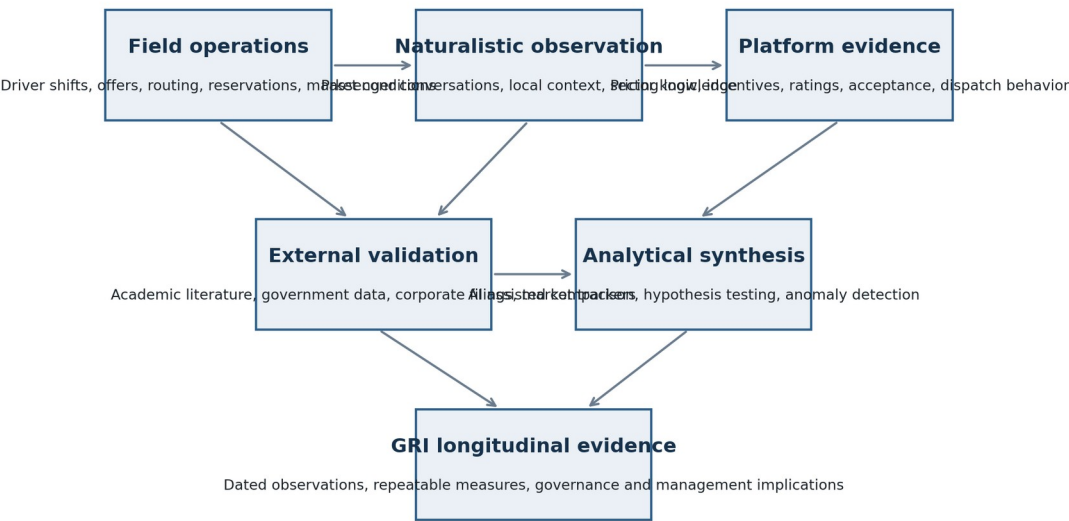
Algorithmic management, naturalistic observation, global mobility and the South Florida rideshare marketplace

Research entry dated October 7, 2026

Prepared for Grand Research Institute
David Grand | Founder and Executive Director

This report consolidates the October 7 research entry with prior GRI rideshare work, current public market data, academic research and a formal framework for continued longitudinal study.

GRI research architecture: operating activity as a longitudinal research instrument



Core proposition

Driving for Uber was not simply transportation work. It functioned as sustained access to a large scale, algorithmically managed labor and mobility system, while also creating repeated naturalistic contact with passengers across occupations, geographies and social contexts.

Research status: ongoing observational and longitudinal program. Findings below distinguish documented data, researcher observations, interpretive hypotheses and questions requiring formal empirical testing.

Executive summary

The October 7 entry clarifies the deeper value of the GRI rideshare program. The vehicle was simultaneously a workplace, a mobility node, an observation point and a recurring interface with one of the most mature algorithmic management environments in the world. The research opportunity exists because Uber combines scale, software mediated management, measurable economic outcomes, geographic variation and continuous human interaction.

- GRI has treated rideshare as a living management laboratory, with more than a decade of direct exposure, more than 20,000 passenger trips reported across the broader rideshare history, and more than one million miles of mobility experience documented across prior GRI work.
- Uber is itself a globally consequential system. The company reported 13.567 billion trips and \$193.454 billion in gross bookings in 2025, with more than 200 million monthly platform consumers by the fourth quarter. Its 2025 filing states that its technology was available in more than 70 countries and more than 15,000 cities.
- The management layer is computational. Dispatch, pricing, incentives, performance feedback, ratings, labor supply signals and aspects of compensation are mediated through software. Academic research has long identified information asymmetries and indirect control in Uber work, while newer research continues to examine trust, transparency, compensation opacity and worker outcomes.
- The passenger environment created a second research stream: repeated naturalistic conversations with people who were not recruited into a conventional study. This can reduce some demand characteristics and impression management associated with formal interviews, but it does not establish that passengers are always truthful. The defensible claim is that the setting can elicit less scripted, more context rich accounts that can generate hypotheses for later validation.
- South Florida remains a particularly useful economic test bed. Current third party tracking places Miami Uber earnings around \$18.73 per hour and Lyft around \$16.73 per hour gross, compared with a \$15 Florida employee minimum wage, \$24.59 mean hourly pay for Miami transportation occupations and \$32.30 across all Miami occupations. These are not directly equivalent measures, but the gap is analytically important.
- The next phase should convert the research program into a reproducible evidence system with offer level data, explicit denominators for active and online time, operating cost tracking, deidentified field notes, geographic coding and documented validation against academic, government and corporate sources.

Uber platform scale: why the system is a consequential management laboratory



Figure 1. Uber platform scale based on 2025 company reporting and February 2026 investor communication.

1. Research entry: October 7, 2026

The central observation is that driving for Uber created research access that would have been difficult to replicate through a conventional office based study. Daily platform participation exposed the researcher to the operating logic of algorithmic management as it was being experienced in real time: changing demand signals, pricing, dispatch, navigation, incentive systems, ratings, reservation products, marketplace imbalances, customer behavior and the transfer of operational risk to the driver supplied vehicle.

At the same time, each shift created repeated contact with passengers. Over years, those interactions spanned business leaders, attorneys, public officials, workers, tourists, retirees, students, families and people from many national and ideological backgrounds. That diversity made the rideshare environment useful for exploratory management and institutional research because conversations could reveal how people described their industries, institutions, incentives, frustrations and decisions outside a formal survey setting.

The research value did not come from assuming that every passenger account was accurate. It came from pattern recognition across repeated encounters, followed by verification. The GRI model therefore uses passenger conversation as a hypothesis generating input, not as self validating evidence. Claims are strengthened only when corroborated through additional observations, public records, academic literature, corporate reporting, government data or other independent sources.

The defensible version of the “passenger does not lie to the Uber driver” insight

Informal formulation	Research formulation
“The passenger is not going to lie to the Uber driver.”	A low stakes, naturally occurring conversation may reduce some social desirability pressure, strategic messaging and demand characteristics compared with a compensated formal interview.
“You can tell who someone is through probing questions.”	Experienced conversational probing can reveal domain knowledge, confidence, inconsistencies and contextual detail, but identity or expertise must be independently verified before being treated as fact.
“The ride becomes the research study.”	The ride becomes an observational setting that can generate field notes and hypotheses. Formal human subjects findings require appropriate ethics review, consent structure or a determination that the activity is outside regulated human subjects research.

2. Uber as an algorithmic management system

The managerial significance of Uber is larger than rideshare. It is a mature example of management functions being delegated to computational systems. The driver receives work opportunities, compensation signals, routing suggestions, quality feedback, incentives and behavioral prompts through an application rather than through a conventional supervisor. This makes rideshare relevant to broader leadership questions about authority, discretion, accountability, information asymmetry and worker agency in AI mediated organizations.

Management function	Platform mechanism	GRI research question
Task allocation	Automated matching and dispatch	Who receives which revenue opportunities, and on what observable basis?
Compensation	Upfront driver pay, surge and incentive logic	Does the system create stable wage like outcomes even when each trip is priced separately?
Labor supply	Heat maps, demand signals, bonuses and reservations	How does software shape when and where independent workers choose to work?
Performance	Ratings, cancellation and acceptance behavior	How does continuous measurement alter worker behavior and perceived autonomy?
Experimentation	Feature and pricing tests	How should governance address unequal exposure to platform experiments?
Information control	Platform wide visibility versus driver local visibility	What decisions become asymmetric because the platform sees the marketplace more completely?

Rosenblat and Stark identified information and power asymmetries in Uber as early as 2016. Hall and Krueger documented the platform's flexibility and relatively stable hourly earnings across hours worked in an earlier regime. Recent 2026 research continues to show that algorithmic management practices such as monitoring, performance ratings, scheduling and compensation transparency shape worker trust and continuance. GRI extends this literature by emphasizing longitudinal operator observation and the managerial system as it evolves in the field.

3. A global observational platform

Uber's geographic reach makes the application useful for comparative institutional observation. The company reported operations in more than 70 countries and more than 15,000 cities at year end 2025. For GRI, the ability to use rideshare platforms across different countries and to speak with drivers and passengers in multiple settings creates an unusual comparative lens on regulation, infrastructure, labor markets, payment systems, local norms and the way a global platform adapts to national institutions.

This does not make every location a controlled experiment. It does create a structured comparative research opportunity. The same broad platform category can be examined under different regulatory regimes, cultural expectations, fuel costs, traffic systems, labor protections and competitive environments. That is particularly relevant to Thunderbird style global management analysis because the dependent variable is not only business performance. It is also how institutions shape the practical behavior of the system.

Comparative dimensions for the continuing GRI project

- Pricing transparency and driver information before acceptance
- Contractor classification and social protection
- Fuel and vehicle cost burden
- Insurance and safety rules
- Rating systems and deactivation procedures
- Local competition among Uber, Lyft, taxis and regional platforms
- Autonomous vehicle integration and human driver displacement or complementarity
- Consumer expectations, tipping norms and service standards
- Institutional recourse when an automated decision affects income or access to work

GRI research architecture: operating activity as a longitudinal research instrument

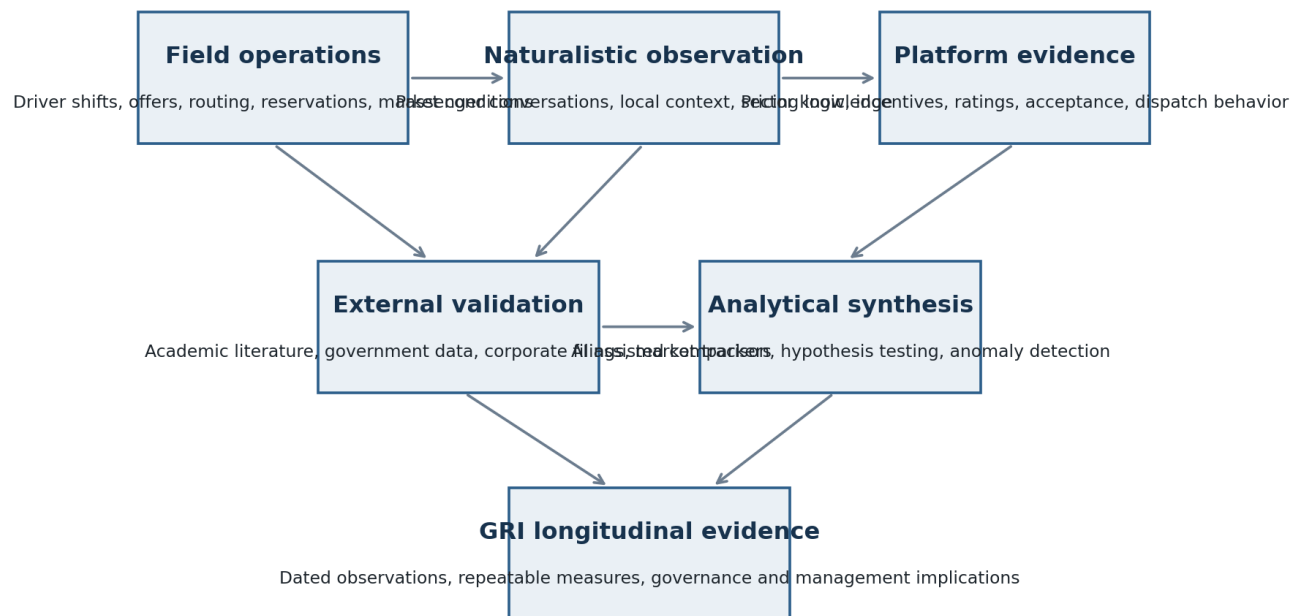


Figure 2. The GRI research model combines direct field activity, naturalistic observation, platform evidence and external validation.

4. Naturalistic conversation as a research instrument

The passenger interaction layer is one of the most distinctive elements of the project. Conventional research often changes the behavior it seeks to measure. Participants know they are being studied, may receive compensation, may try to provide socially acceptable answers, or may answer in ways shaped by professional, political or organizational interests. A rideshare conversation can be different because it begins as an ordinary service interaction rather than a formal interview.

This setting may reduce some forms of response engineering, but it introduces other biases. The sample is not random. Riders are self selected by geography, time, platform use and trip purpose. Memory can be inaccurate. People can exaggerate, conceal information or misrepresent expertise. The researcher can also influence the conversation through question wording and selective recall. Therefore the appropriate methodological classification is exploratory naturalistic observation with structured verification, not a representative survey of public opinion.

GRI validation protocol

- Capture only deidentified field notes unless explicit permission exists for attribution.
- Separate direct observation from inference in the research log.
- Tag each insight by subject area, geography, date and confidence level.
- Where a passenger makes a factual or professional claim, seek independent confirmation before using it analytically.
- Aggregate patterns across multiple encounters rather than treating a single ride as representative.
- Use the ASU library, peer reviewed literature, government data and primary corporate records for triangulation.
- For any future study intended as formal human subjects research, obtain the appropriate institutional ethics or IRB determination before collecting publishable participant data.

5. South Florida marketplace: the approximately \$20 gross earnings hypothesis

GRI's October 5 work identified a testable South Florida pattern: ride offers and observed earnings appeared to cluster near an approximately \$20 gross hourly band. Current Solo tracking is directionally consistent with that observation, reporting \$18.73 per hour for Uber and \$16.73 for Lyft in Miami as of September 30, 2026. These are gross platform earnings and should not be confused with employee wages or net economic income.

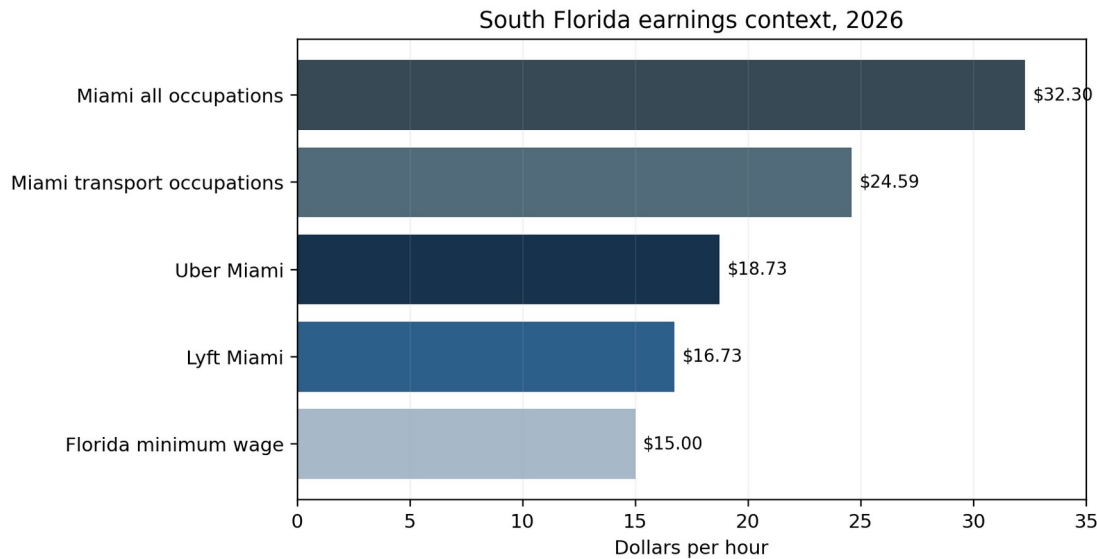


Figure 3. Rideshare figures are third party gross earnings estimates. Florida minimum wage applies to covered employees, not automatically to independent contractors. BLS wage figures exclude the self employed.

The comparison becomes more important once the driver supplied vehicle is treated as productive capital. The IRS increased the optional business mileage rate to \$0.76 per mile for the second half of 2026 in response to higher transportation costs. That rate is not a literal cash expense for every driver, but it is a useful sensitivity benchmark. At 20 business miles per online hour, a \$0.76 benchmark represents \$15.20 of vehicle cost per hour, showing how fragile a gross hourly number near \$20 can become when asset costs are internalized.

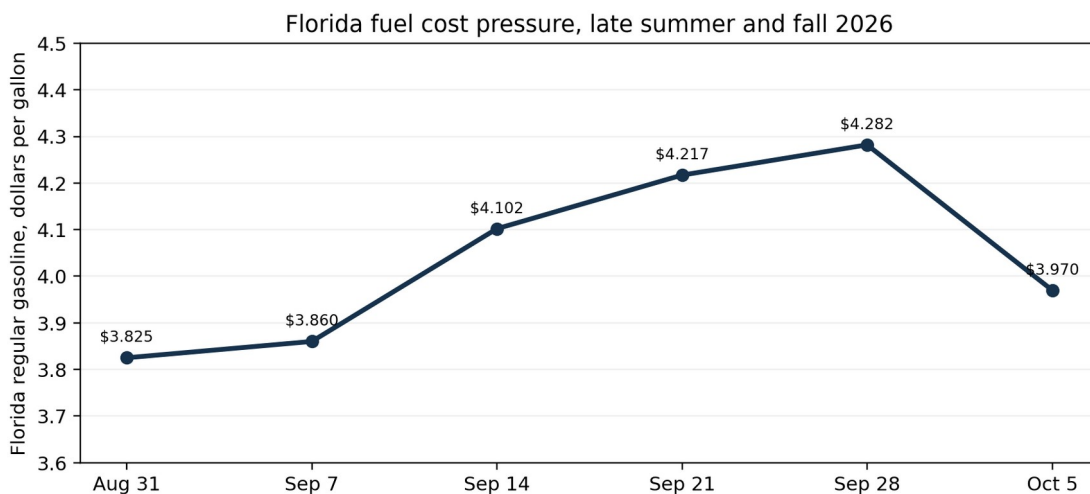


Figure 4. EIA weekly Florida regular gasoline prices. The September 28 price reached \$4.282 per gallon before easing to \$3.970 on October 5.

6. What the \$20 pattern can and cannot establish

The evidence does not establish that Uber or Lyft intentionally programmed a hidden \$20 hourly wage. The more defensible hypothesis is that a dynamic platform can produce an effective earnings equilibrium through matching, pricing, supply balancing and driver response. If thousands of independently priced tasks repeatedly converge into a narrow hourly band, then compensation may be emerging as a property of the management system even without a posted hourly schedule.

The next empirical step is an offer level dataset rather than a dashboard average.

Field	Analytical value
Offer timestamp	Controls time of day and demand conditions
Platform and ride type	Separates UberX, Comfort, Lyft, reservations and other products
Upfront driver pay	Primary compensation variable
Pickup miles and minutes	Measures unpaid approach burden
Trip miles and minutes	Measures productive commitment
Reservation status	Tests scheduled work against spot dispatch
Surge or bonus	Separates incentives from base pricing
Origin and destination zone	Controls spatial effects
Acceptance or rejection	Allows study of response and possible adaptive pricing
Full online time	Prevents active time from overstating hourly returns
Odometer miles	Captures paid, pickup, idle and repositioning miles
Fuel purchase price	Measures current cash pressure
Anonymized driver identifier	Enables driver heterogeneity analysis without exposing identity

Core tests should include concentration around the \$20 band, reservations versus immediate dispatch, driver heterogeneity for economically comparable offers, cost pass through as fuel prices change, and separate reporting of active, engaged and total online time.

7. The GRI Think Tank model

The GRI Think Tank can be understood as a distributed validation network rather than as a traditional Washington style institution built around a single office and formal fellows. Its comparative advantage is proximity to operating systems, rapid access to practitioners across sectors, academic library resources and AI assisted synthesis. The rideshare platform provides the recurring field interface; GRI then connects observations to experts, academic materials, public data and institutional context.

That model is strongest when it avoids overclaiming. The research advantage is speed, exposure and cross sector pattern recognition. The credibility mechanism is documentation and triangulation. In practice, this means a provocative observation from a ride can become a research question within hours, but it becomes a GRI finding only after evidence is accumulated and the competing explanations are considered.

GRI evidence hierarchy

Level	Evidence type	Use
1	Direct operational record	Observed offers, time, miles, app behavior, costs
2	Deidentified naturalistic observation	Hypothesis generation and contextual interpretation
3	Repeated field pattern	Cross ride or cross market pattern recognition
4	Independent external confirmation	Government data, corporate filings, peer reviewed research, third party market data
5	Formal empirical test	Predefined variables, reproducible analysis, documented limitations
6	Publication or governance implication	Only after the evidence chain is explicit

8. Strategic implications for leadership and AI management

The Uber project is relevant beyond transportation because it exposes a general organizational transition: management is moving from explicit human supervision toward software mediated systems that allocate work, measure performance, optimize capacity and influence compensation. The key leadership problem is therefore not whether AI is “the boss.” It is where managerial authority resides, how the system constrains human discretion and who is accountable for persistent outcomes generated by continuous optimization.

- Algorithmic management can create organization wide consistency while making individual decisions less legible to workers.
- Information asymmetry becomes a management resource: the platform sees network wide conditions while the worker sees a local offer.
- Flexibility and control can coexist. A driver may choose when to log in while the platform still structures the economic options available after login.
- Compensation opacity is a governance issue because variable pricing can make it difficult for workers to understand the rule behind an outcome.
- Autonomous vehicles will not eliminate these management questions. They will shift them toward fleet allocation, machine performance, safety governance, human exception handling and the division of value between platform, capital owner and remaining human labor.
- For leadership education, rideshare is a practical bridge between global management, AI governance, labor economics, institutional analysis and Fourth Industrial Revolution strategy.

GRI doctoral linkage

This research supports the broader GRI doctoral architecture that compares algorithmic management of people with rule based systems that constrain management itself. Uber is the mature antecedent case: algorithms allocate work and shape worker behavior. Newer GRI operating projects can become comparative cases in which transparent rules limit organizational discretion. The research question becomes: what happens when algorithmic management controls people versus when algorithmic rules constrain management?

9. Current findings and research claims

Statement	Status	Research posture
Uber is a globally scaled algorithmic management environment.	Strongly supported	Company reporting and academic literature.
The driver app delegates multiple traditional management functions to software.	Strongly supported	Direct observation plus academic and corporate sources.
Naturalistic passenger conversations can produce valuable unscripted insight.	Supported as method	Useful for hypothesis generation, not representative inference.
Passengers are more truthful with an Uber driver than in paid research.	Not established as a universal claim	Reframe as reduced demand characteristics in some contexts, subject to verification.
South Florida rideshare gross earnings currently cluster near \$20 per hour.	Preliminary but externally corroborated	Third party Miami tracking plus GRI observations.
Uber or Lyft intentionally targets a hidden \$20 hourly wage.	Not established	Requires matched offer level causal evidence.
The research program has value as a longitudinal study of AI, labor and management.	Strongly supported as research design	Value increases with standardized data capture and transparent methodology.

The most important achievement of the program is the construction of a durable observational position inside a changing management system. Retrospective studies can reconstruct a market after the fact. GRI has the opportunity to document the transition while pricing architecture, labor conditions, fuel economics, regulation and autonomous mobility are changing simultaneously.

10. Recommended next phase: evidence system for 2026 to 2027

- Create a single standardized offer log covering platform, product, timestamp, pickup burden, trip commitment, pay, surge, reservation status, origin, destination and acceptance decision.
- Capture daily online time, active time, odometer movement and fuel purchases to separate platform gross earnings from economic income.
- Create a deidentified field note taxonomy for passenger derived insights: sector, topic, geography, claim type, confidence and validation status.
- Add a verification field that links each material claim to an academic source, government series, corporate filing or second independent observation.
- Preserve snapshots of platform terms and pricing explanations because the product architecture changes over time.
- Run monthly South Florida dashboards and quarterly comparative market briefs.
- Build a global comparison matrix as travel and platform access permit, focusing on institutions rather than anecdotal country rankings.
- Before converting passenger observations into formal publishable human subjects evidence, obtain the appropriate ethics or IRB determination.
- Use AI as an analytical assistant for coding, anomaly detection and source comparison, while retaining human approval over research claims and publication.

Proposed headline research question

How does algorithmic management shape compensation, worker behavior, information asymmetry and institutional accountability across markets, and what can longitudinal operator observation reveal that conventional platform datasets miss?

Sources and research basis

Primary and academic sources used in this October 7 consolidation are listed below. GRI internal observations are identified separately and should not be confused with independent validation.

1. Uber Technologies, Inc. “Uber Announces Results for Fourth Quarter and Full Year 2025,” February 4, 2026. Reports 13.567 billion 2025 trips, \$193.454 billion gross bookings, 202 million Q4 monthly active platform consumers and more than 72 billion cumulative trips.
2. Uber Technologies, Inc. Form 10 K for year ended December 31, 2025. Reports technology available in more than 70 countries and more than 15,000 cities.
3. Lyft, Inc. Form 10 K for year ended December 31, 2025. Reports 945.5 million rides and \$18.507 billion gross bookings in 2025.
4. U.S. Energy Information Administration. Florida weekly retail gasoline prices. Regular gasoline: \$3.825 on August 31, \$4.282 on September 28 and \$3.970 on October 5, 2026.
5. Internal Revenue Service, Announcement 2026 11. Revised optional business mileage rate of \$0.76 per mile effective July 1, 2026.
6. Florida Department of Commerce. Florida minimum wage, \$15.00 per hour effective September 30, 2026.
7. U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics. Occupational Employment and Wages in Miami Fort Lauderdale West Palm Beach, May 2025, published July 7, 2026. Mean hourly wage: \$24.59 for transportation and material moving occupations and \$32.30 for all occupations.
8. Solo. “Uber Pay in Miami (FL)” and “Lyft Pay in Miami (FL),” updated September 30, 2026. Reported gross hourly estimates of \$18.73 and \$16.73 respectively.
9. Rosenblat, A., and Stark, L. “Algorithmic Labor and Information Asymmetries: A Case Study of Uber’s Drivers.” *International Journal of Communication* 10, 2016.
10. Hall, J. V., and Krueger, A. B. “An Analysis of the Labor Market for Uber’s Driver Partners in the United States.” *ILR Review* 71, no. 3, 2018, 705 to 732.
11. Berg, J., and Johnston, H. “Too Good to Be True? A Comment on Hall and Krueger’s Analysis of the Labor Market for Uber’s Driver Partners.” *ILR Review* 72, no. 1, 2019, 39 to 68.
12. Chen, M. K., Feinerman, K., and Haggag, K. “Flexible Pay and Labor Supply: Evidence from Uber’s Instant Pay.” NBER Working Paper 33177, 2024.
13. “Algorithmic management practices, trust, and gig worker continuance: A mixed methods study of platform work.” *Technology in Society* 87, 2026, 103394.
14. Li, Y., Zhao, L., Cao, C., and Yang, D. “The double edged sword effect of algorithmic transparency: An empirical study of gig workers’ work disengagement under algorithmic management.” *Information & Management* 62, no. 2, 2025, 104100.
15. Grand Research Institute. “Algorithmic Management and the Approximately \$20 Gross Earnings Band.” Research brief dated October 5, 2026. Internal GRI longitudinal research series.

Internal research note

Prior GRI project records report more than a decade of rideshare experience, more than 20,000 passenger trips, more than one million miles, and repeated use of rideshare work as an operating research environment. These figures are researcher reported and should be supported by platform records where used in external academic publication.

Conclusion: the ride as research infrastructure

The October 7 entry reframes more than a decade of rideshare activity as research infrastructure. The value of the platform was not merely the number of miles driven or rides completed. It was the sustained combination of algorithmic exposure, economic measurement, geographic mobility and repeated contact with people operating inside many different institutions. That combination produced a longitudinal vantage point that can now be formalized, tested and connected to a broader program on AI, management and governance.

The strongest contribution is methodological. GRI can observe an algorithmic management system from the position of a worker operator, compare what the platform communicates with what the market produces, capture human reactions in natural settings and then validate those observations against formal sources. Few research designs combine those layers over such a long operating period.

The next standard is reproducibility. Future value will come from consistent data capture, transparent distinctions between observation and inference, independent validation and ethics appropriate to any use of human interaction data. That is what converts a decade of experience into a defensible longitudinal research asset.

Methodological caution

This report is a strategic research working paper, not a peer reviewed causal study. It intentionally distinguishes observation, external evidence and hypothesis. No claim is made that Uber, Lyft or another platform intentionally fixes driver wages at a specific hourly target, and no claim is made that informal passenger statements are inherently truthful.

ALGORITHMIC MANAGEMENT AND THE APPROXIMATELY \$20 GROSS EARNINGS BAND

A real time South Florida rideshare research brief on platform wage setting, driver economics, and management in the Fourth Industrial Revolution

Grand Research Institute

Research date: October 5, 2026

Geographic focus: Miami and South Florida

Research proposition. Current South Florida observations suggest that rideshare driver offers may be converging around a gross hourly earnings band near \$20. The evidence does not establish that a platform has programmed a \$20 target. It does justify a formal hypothesis: algorithmic dispatch and upfront pricing may produce an effective earnings equilibrium that behaves like an hourly compensation band even though drivers are nominally paid by trip.

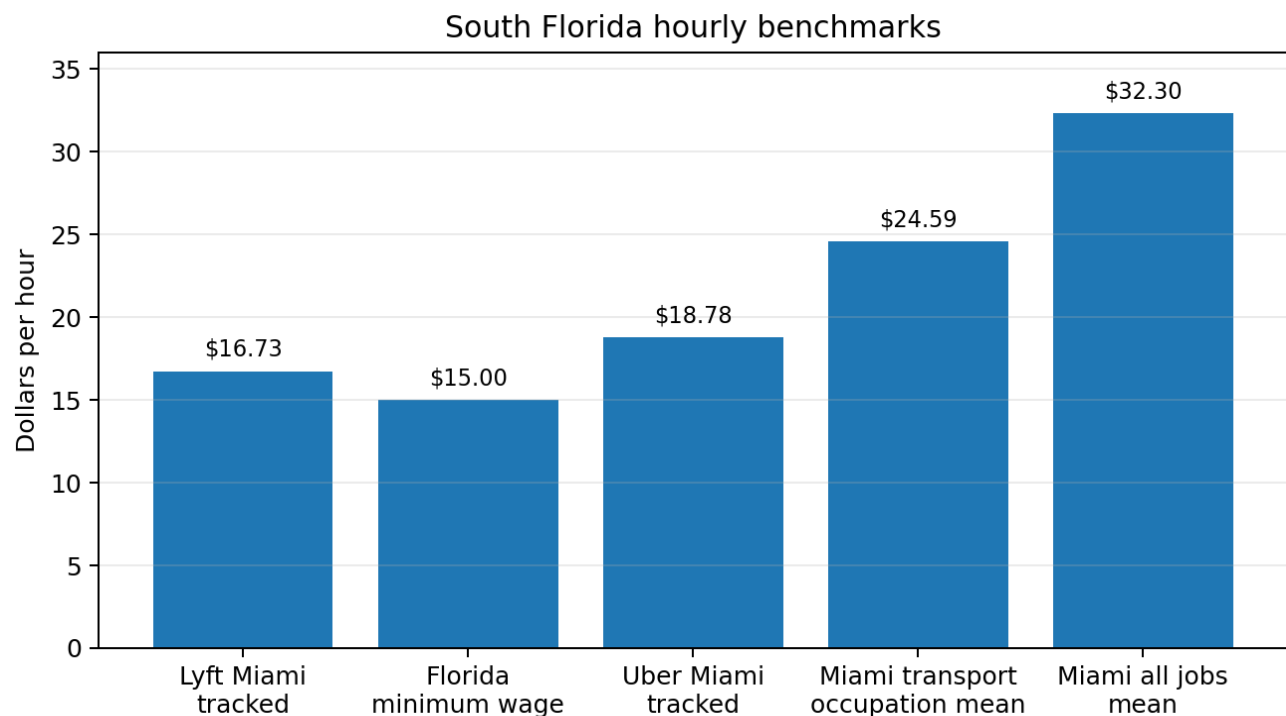


Figure 1. Current Miami driver tracking compared with public wage benchmarks. Rideshare figures are gross platform earnings before the driver's full operating costs.

Executive summary

1. The observed band is externally corroborated. Solo's September 2026 Miami tracking reports Uber at \$18.78 per hour and Lyft at \$16.73 per hour. Gridwise reports a national 2025 median Lyft gross figure of \$20.38 per work hour and an Uber average of \$23.88 per active work hour, but Gridwise emphasizes that active time excludes idle time. These different methodologies make the South Florida clustering near \$20 economically plausible rather than anomalous.

2. Platform pricing architecture can create a de facto hourly outcome without an explicit hourly wage. Uber states that upfront fares can incorporate estimated trip length, duration, pickup distance, surge, real time demand, and destination demand. It also states that pricing functionality may be tested with different groups of drivers. These features create the technical capacity for dynamic compensation to converge toward a platform selected marketplace objective, even if the platform never posts an hourly target.

3. Gross earnings and labor income are not equivalent. Florida's employee minimum wage is now \$15.00 per hour. Independent contractors do not automatically receive the same FLSA wage protections. Driver revenue must fund fuel, depreciation, maintenance, insurance exposure, tires, cleaning, financing, and uncompensated repositioning or waiting time.

4. Vehicle costs have intensified during 2026. EIA data show Florida regular gasoline rising from \$2.843 per gallon on March 2 to \$4.282 on September 28, an increase of approximately 50.6 percent. The IRS responded to higher fuel costs by increasing the optional business mileage rate to \$0.76 per mile beginning July 1, 2026.

5. The management significance is larger than rideshare. The core Fourth Industrial Revolution issue is the transfer of management functions from human supervisors to computational systems. Dispatch, task allocation, pricing, incentives, performance monitoring, labor supply balancing, and increasingly compensation are being executed through software. This makes rideshare a mature empirical case of algorithmic management.

Primary conclusion

The strongest defensible conclusion is not that Uber or Lyft has intentionally fixed driver wages at \$20 per hour. The stronger research conclusion is that current South Florida outcomes are consistent with an algorithmically mediated gross earnings equilibrium near that level. When business costs and unpaid time are incorporated, a driver can fall below the economic value of Florida's \$15 employee minimum wage even when the platform dashboard displays gross earnings near \$20.

1. What the current South Florida data show

Measure	Current value	Interpretation
Uber, Miami	\$18.78 per hour	Solo tracked gross platform earnings, updated Sep. 23, 2026
Lyft, Miami	\$16.73 per hour	Solo tracked gross platform earnings, updated Sep. 30, 2026
Florida minimum wage	\$15.00 per hour	Employee wage floor effective Sep. 30, 2026
Miami transport occupations	\$24.59 per hour	BLS mean wage, May 2025 occupational estimate
Miami all occupations	\$32.30 per hour	BLS mean wage, May 2025 occupational estimate
IRS business mileage proxy	\$0.76 per mile	Optional tax cost benchmark effective Jul. 1, 2026

The proximity of the two Miami platform figures to the \$20 field observation is notable, but it is not by itself causal evidence. The correct research posture is triangulation: compare offer level observations, platform reported pricing architecture, third party earnings tracking, total online time, and operating cost intensity.

A methodological warning about hourly figures

Hourly earnings can change materially depending on the denominator. Active time may count only time associated with accepted work. Online time can include waiting, rejected offers, repositioning, and other availability time. Gridwise explicitly notes that its \$23.88 Uber figure for 2025 is based on active work time and that idle miles represented about 30 percent of total miles. Berkeley researchers similarly emphasize that excluding waiting time can materially overstate net hourly earnings.

2. Why a stable earnings band can emerge

Traditional taxi compensation was legible: a meter linked price to time and distance. Upfront pricing changes the management architecture. The platform can estimate the total economic commitment of an assignment, observe real time demand and supply, present a discrete offer, and learn from acceptance or rejection behavior. The result is not merely automated dispatch. It is computational labor management.

Management function	Algorithmic mechanism	Research implication
Task allocation	Assign ride requests to available drivers	Controls access to revenue opportunities
Compensation	Generate upfront fare from trip and marketplace variables	Can decouple pay from a transparent meter
Labor supply	Use surge, bonuses, heat maps, and demand signals	Shapes when and where drivers work
Performance	Ratings, acceptance patterns, cancellations, trip history	Creates continuous behavioral data
Experimentation	Pricing or functionality tests across driver groups	Supports iterative optimization
Information control	Platform observes marketplace conditions more completely than individual drivers	Creates structural information asymmetry

Academic literature provides several conceptual mechanisms. Hall and Krueger documented relatively stable Uber hourly earnings across hours worked in an earlier regime. Chen and Sheldon showed that dynamic pricing influences driver labor supply. Dubal identifies the possibility of algorithmic wage discrimination through granular worker data and variable personalized pay. Recent research on algorithmic assignment also shows that assignment rules themselves can alter hourly earnings. None of these papers proves that current Miami pricing targets \$20. Together they establish that platforms have both the economic incentive and the technical mechanisms to manage labor supply and compensation algorithmically.

3. Gross revenue versus economic income

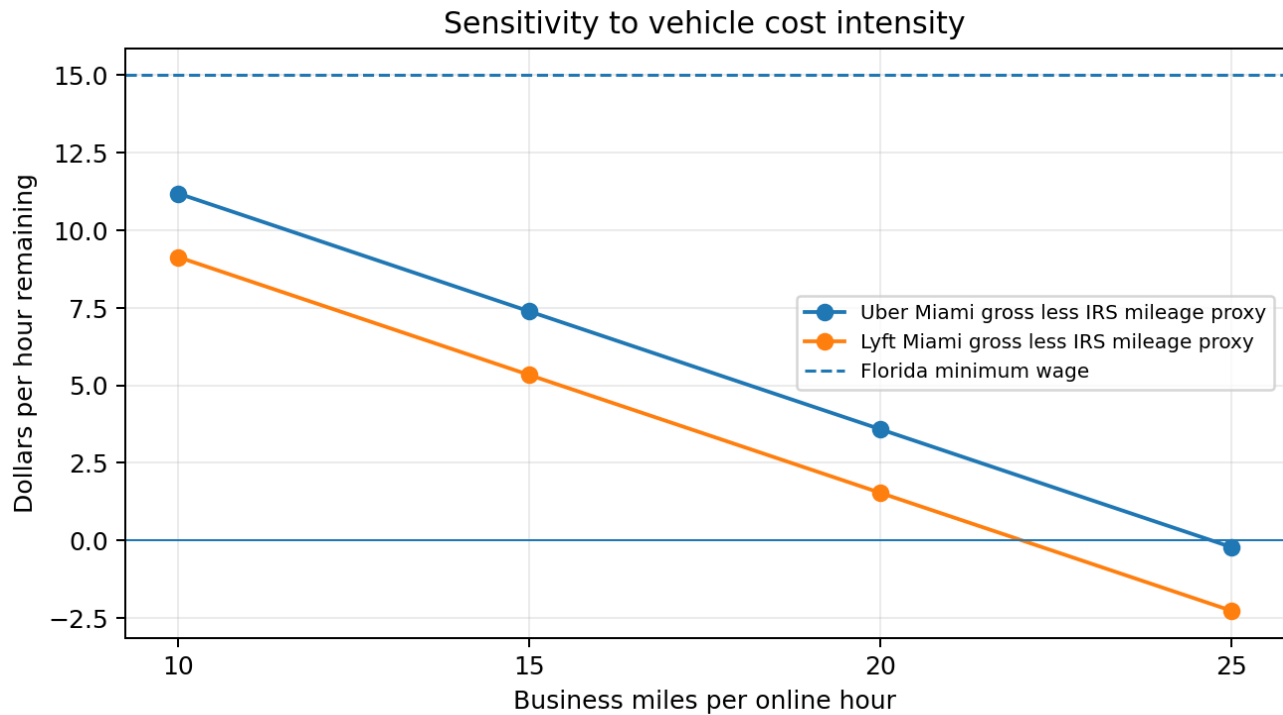


Figure 2. Sensitivity using the IRS \$0.76 per mile business mileage rate as a broad cost proxy. This is not a literal cash expense estimate for each driver. It is a benchmark designed to capture the economic burden of business vehicle use.

At 20 business miles per online hour, applying the IRS proxy leaves approximately \$3.58 from an \$18.78 Uber gross hour and \$1.53 from a \$16.73 Lyft gross hour. Those values should not be described as wages because the IRS rate is a tax benchmark encompassing multiple vehicle cost components. The point is sensitivity: a gross hourly number only modestly above minimum wage can be economically fragile when the worker supplies the capital asset.

A more conservative cash view still shows pressure. At 20 vehicle miles in an hour and 25 miles per gallon, fuel alone costs about \$3.43 using the September 28 EIA Florida regular price of \$4.282. At the GRI field scenario of \$5.00 per gallon, fuel alone reaches \$4.00 per hour. These calculations still exclude maintenance, tires, depreciation, insurance, cleaning, financing, taxes, and uncompensated vehicle use.

4. The 2026 cost shock

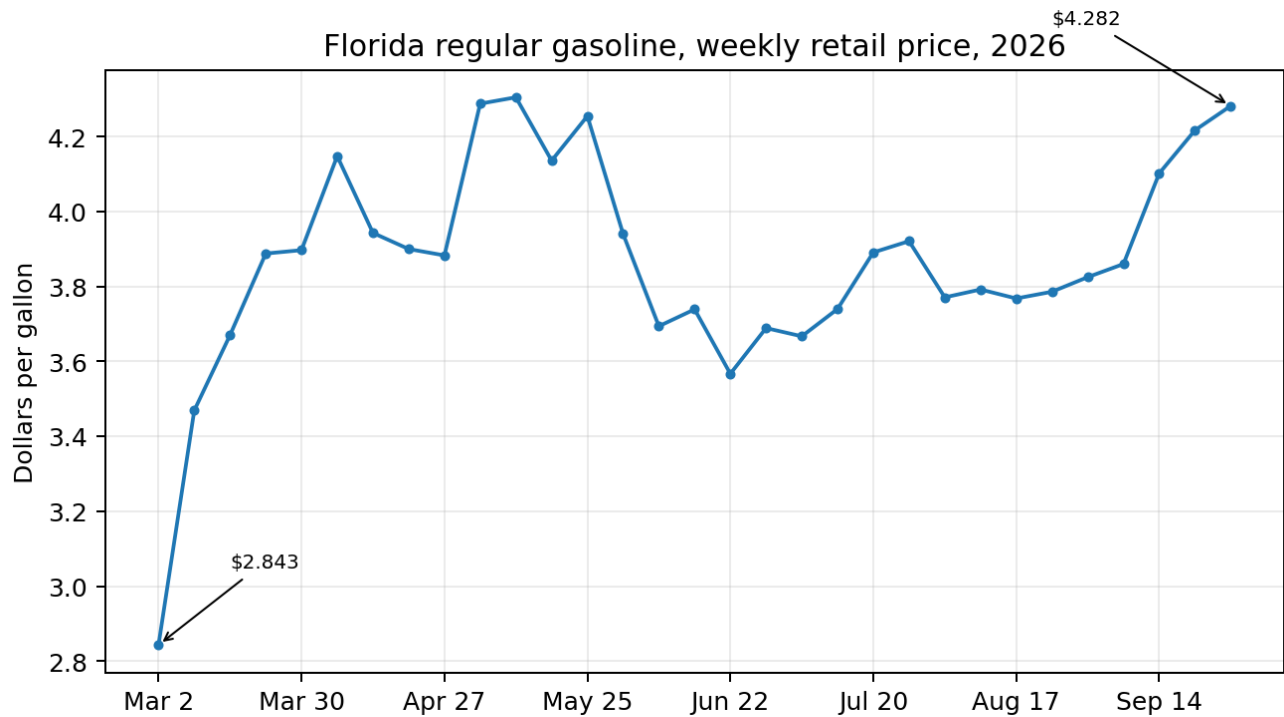
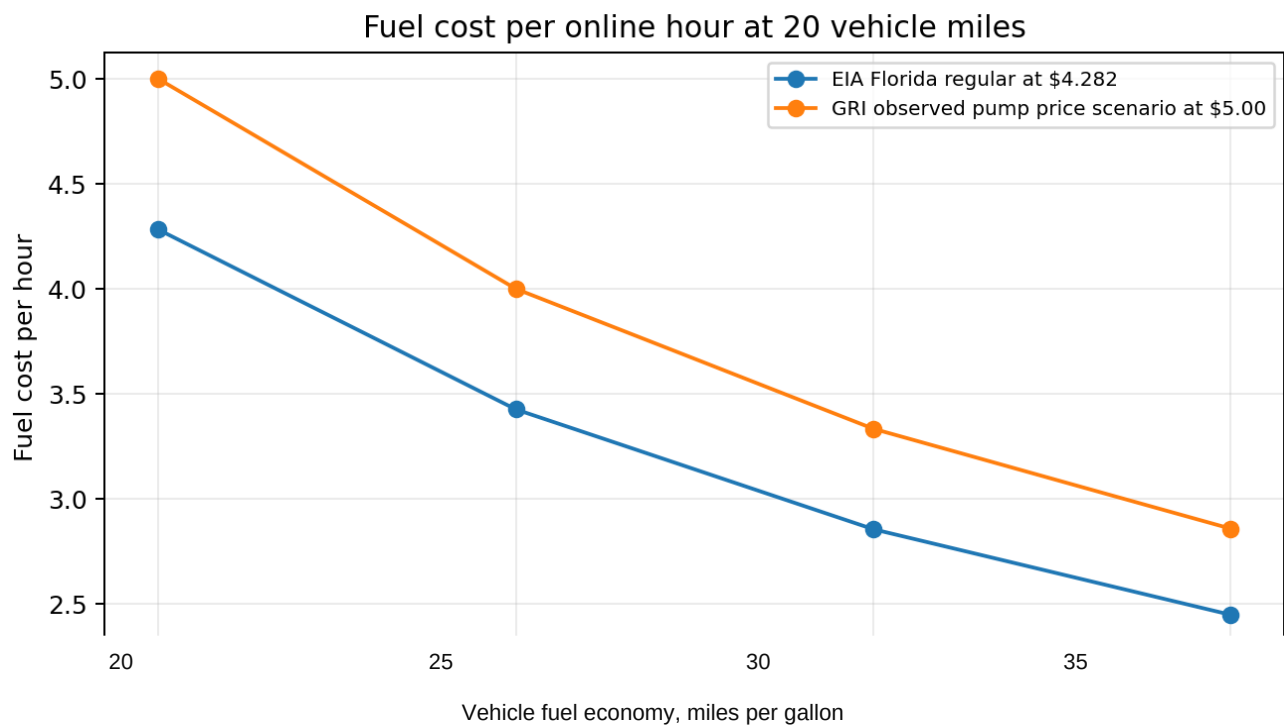


Figure 3. U.S. Energy Information Administration weekly Florida regular gasoline series. March 2 through September 28, 2026.

Florida regular gasoline increased from \$2.843 per gallon on March 2 to \$4.282 on September 28, approximately 50.6 percent. The IRS then increased its optional business mileage rate from \$0.725 to \$0.76 per mile effective July 1, specifically citing recent fuel price increases. For a platform worker whose nominal gross hourly revenue is relatively stable, this creates an asymmetric shock: the platform's displayed gross compensation can remain near the same level while the driver's real economic return falls.



5. What the academic literature adds

Study	Core contribution to this research
Hall and Krueger, ILR Review, 2018	Early administrative and survey evidence on Uber labor supply and hourly earnings. Establishes rideshare as a flexible labor market.
Chen et al., NBER, 2017/2019	Quantifies the value drivers place on schedule flexibility. Important because flexibility can coexist with lower or more volatile earnings.
Chen and Sheldon, AEA conference paper	Shows surge pricing affects driver labor supply, demonstrating that algorithmic price signals can actively manage labor supply.
Dubal, Columbia Law Review, 2023	Develops the concept of algorithmic wage discrimination: granular worker data can support unpredictable, variable wages.
Transportation Research Part A, 2019	Shows advertised gross hourly earnings can overstate driver economics once unpaid time and vehicle expenses are accounted for.
UC Berkeley Labor Center, 2024	Across five metro areas, a majority of sampled gig passenger and delivery drivers earned less than the applicable minimum wage.
UC Berkeley IRLE, 2026	Argues that excluding rejected offer time, understating expenses, and counting tips can materially overstate net Uber earnings.
Transportation Research Interdisciplinary Perspectives, 2025	Empirical evidence shows a large gap between engaged hour gross earnings and in app hour net earnings, highlighting the importance of accounting for all costs.

The literature therefore supports a critical distinction for GRI: platform flexibility and algorithmic control are not opposites. A worker can choose when to log on while the platform retains substantial control over which opportunities are presented, how they are priced, how incentives are structured, and how market information is distributed.

6. GRI research model: testing the approximately \$20 hypothesis

The next phase should move from observation to a reproducible offer level dataset. The unit of analysis should be each ride offer, not merely the completed trip. That allows GRI to test whether the platform is stabilizing expected gross hourly compensation, whether pricing varies systematically across drivers, and how costs transform displayed earnings into economic income.

Field	Why it matters
Offer timestamp	Controls for demand conditions and time of day
Platform and ride type	Separates UberX, Comfort, Lyft, reservations, and other products
Upfront driver pay	Dependent compensation variable
Pickup miles and minutes	Measures uncompensated approach burden
Trip miles and minutes	Measures productive ride commitment
Total estimated minutes	Creates implied gross dollars per committed hour
Reservation status	Tests whether scheduled work converges more tightly than spot dispatch
Surge or bonus	Separates base algorithmic price from incentives
Origin and destination zone	Controls spatial market effects
Acceptance or rejection	Enables study of learning and offer adjustment
Actual online time	Supports active versus online denominator comparison
Odometer miles	Captures paid, pickup, idle, and repositioning miles
Fuel purchase price	Measures current cash cost
Driver identifier, anonymized	Tests inter driver variation without exposing identities

Core empirical tests

Band concentration test. Calculate implied dollars per committed hour for every offer and measure the distribution around \$20.

Reservation comparison. Compare scheduled reservation offers with real time dispatch. Lower variance in reservations would strengthen the argument that the system prices time commitments systematically.

Driver heterogeneity test. Compare economically similar offers across anonymized drivers. Persistent differences would be relevant to the algorithmic wage discrimination literature.

Cost pass through test. Compare gross platform earnings with fuel and mileage cost changes over time. If driver gross remains stable while operating costs rise, real economic compensation declines.

Denominator test. Report active time, engaged time, and full online time separately. This prevents an hourly figure from being inflated by excluding uncompensated availability.

7. Strategic interpretation for management and the Fourth Industrial Revolution

Rideshare is no longer simply a transportation sector case. It is a management system in which software performs functions historically assigned to dispatchers, supervisors, schedulers, compensation managers, quality control teams, and workforce planners. The worker remains human, but the managerial layer is increasingly computational.

That distinction is central to the Grand Research Institute research program. The managerial question is not whether an algorithm is literally a person's boss. The question is which management functions have been delegated to computational systems, what authority those systems exercise, what information asymmetries they create, and where accountability resides when a machine generated compensation regime produces persistent economic outcomes.

The \$20 finding is therefore useful precisely because it is mundane. If thousands of individually priced tasks can converge on a narrow hourly economic outcome without a posted wage schedule, then wage setting itself may be becoming an emergent property of algorithmic management. That is a Fourth Industrial Revolution governance issue: management can move from explicit human rules toward continuously optimized computational decisions whose aggregate effect is easier to observe than the underlying rule.

What can be stated now

Current evidence supports documenting an approximately \$20 gross earnings band as a **testable empirical pattern** in South Florida rideshare. It supports the proposition that algorithmic pricing and dispatch can generate wage like outcomes. It does not yet establish intentional wage fixing, a specific hidden target, or individualized discrimination by a particular platform. Those stronger claims require matched offer level evidence.

Why real time documentation matters

The platform, pricing model, fuel environment, driver supply, autonomous vehicle deployment, and regulatory framework are changing simultaneously. Retrospective research can miss these transitions. A contemporaneous longitudinal record allows GRI to capture the managerial system while it is evolving, including changes in pricing logic, cost transfer, human labor utilization, and the eventual interaction between human drivers and autonomous fleets.

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GRI field evidence. The report incorporates the October 5, 2026 Grand Research Institute observation that current South Florida ride offers and reservation checks are clustering near approximately \$20 gross per hour, together with a \$5 per gallon field fuel price scenario. These observations are identified separately from official statewide data and are treated as hypotheses for systematic longitudinal testing.

Analytical note. This brief distinguishes measured data from interpretation. The IRS mileage rate is used only as a broad cost sensitivity benchmark and should not be read as the precise operating cost of any individual driver. No claim is made that Uber, Lyft, or another platform intentionally sets a hidden \$20 hourly wage. The research question is whether dynamic platform management produces a stable effective earnings band.